



No real cats were used in Erwin's famous thought experiment!

Schrödinger's cat

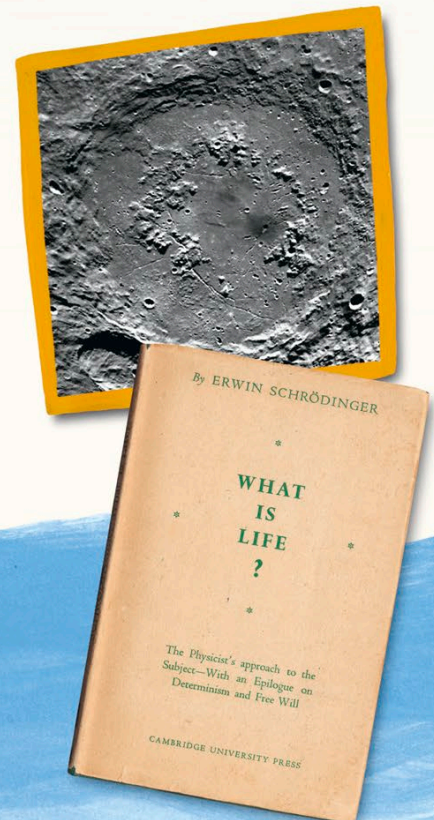
Erwin's most famous thought experiment imagines that a cat in a closed box will die if a single particle breaks apart. Quantum mechanics doesn't tell us exactly when this will happen—only the probability that it will happen after a certain time. So, the conclusion is that the cat could be both alive and dead at the same time.

The Schrödinger crater is a huge moon crater named in Erwin's honor.

Science and politics

In 1933, Erwin was awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics. He moved to Germany and began working alongside Albert Einstein. Life in Germany, however, was changing quickly. The country was now ruled by the Nazi Party and its leader, Adolf Hitler. The Nazis began by taking away the right of many people, including all Jewish people, to live like everyone else in Germany—they even banned them from certain jobs.

Erwin disagreed with the way the Nazis treated Jewish people, and, like many other leading scientists, he decided to leave Germany. Erwin worked in universities around the world before returning permanently to his home country of Austria in 1955.



In his book What is Life?, Erwin used the word "code" to describe how genes carry information—before DNA was found.

"I do not know whether my way of approach is really the best and simplest. But, in short, it was mine."